

Notes & Source

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A HARMONY OF THE GOSPELS BY CHRONOLOGY AND TOPICS

GOSPELS

SIDE BY SIDE

Matthew • Mark • Luke • John

ROSE PUBLISHING

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The First Gospel

Because the first three Gospels so closely resemble each other, the question has long been asked, “Who wrote first?” Many modern scholars are inclined in favor of Mark as being the first Gospel in print. This is due in part to the brevity of the work and the fact that most of Mark's material can also be found in Matthew and Luke. The idea is that if Mark wrote first, Luke and Matthew might have read his work and added their own material in their writing. Early tradition holds that Mark became associated with Peter and that his Gospel might be a kind of “Memoirs of Peter.” Its rapid-fire style seems like Peter's way of recounting Jesus' life.

Others are convinced, however, that none of the Gospels that exists today was the first to be in print. These scholars believe that there was an earlier writing that the authors of the present Gospels (Matthew, Mark, and Luke) drew upon as a reference work. Papias, an early Christian and disciple of the Apostle John, wrote that Matthew put together the sayings in the Hebrew language, and each one interpreted them as best he could (in Eusebius, Ecclesiastical History 3.39.16). Since Matthew was a tax collector (Matthew 9:9), he was a good pick to be the scribe among the disciples, so this tradition may bear some weight. It may be that Matthew recorded much of what happened in Jesus' ministry in the native tongue of Palestine. This document may later have been translated into Greek and used by him and the other synoptic writers to produce our present Gospels.

The Gospels as we now have them were first written in Greek, which was the popular common language of the Roman world. It is entirely possible that Matthew made the first record in Aramaic, but that Mark drafted the first Gospel in Greek, drawing on Matthew's record and adding what he had heard from Peter. Luke and Matthew (in present form) would then have been written. John wrote his account after the others had been in circulation for some time.

The Synoptic Gospels and John

The word “synoptic” means “seen together.” It refers to the first three Gospels: Matthew, Mark, and Luke. When seen together, these Gospels often reveal related accounts in very similar language. Scholars agree there is some relationship between these three books. The exact nature of this relationship has been the subject of much debate. It seems that these three authors either read one another or some common source, which explains why so much of their substance and language are the same.

The Gospel of John, however, is different from the first three Gospels. John uses material that the other writers do not have. The wording of some of the stories is different. John often added details that the others do not include—for example, the name of the woman who washed Jesus' feet with her hair (John 12:3), or that he beat Peter in a foot race to the empty tomb on Easter Sunday (John 20:4). Many of these details have a personal tone.

The Synoptic Gospels Compared to John — Three Examples

Gospel Text	Event	Description
Matthew 3:11–12; Mark 1:7–8; Luke 3:15–18	John the Baptist's introduction of Jesus	General and generic language is used about the crowds.
John 1:24–44		John names specific individuals who become disciples of Jesus through John the Baptist.
Matthew 14:13–21; Mark 6:30–44; Luke 9:10–17	Feeding of the 5000	Dialogue with Jesus is attributed to the disciples as a group.
John 6:1–14		John names specific individuals who speak.
Matthew 28:1–10; Mark 16:1–11; Luke 24:1–12	The Resurrection	Individuals are named in all accounts to a greater or lesser extent.
John 20:1–18		John is specific about the actions of Mary Magdalene, Peter, and himself (the unnamed disciple).

Why Do We Need Four Gospels?

Because the four Gospels contain different accounts of the same or similar events in the life of Jesus, readers of the Gospels have often sought to compare and contrast these accounts by placing them next to each other. These side-by-side comparisons attempt to harmonize the work of the four Evangelists and so are often called “Gospel Harmonies.”

Four Points of View

Gospel	Symbol	Viewpoint	Audience	Jesus the Son of God...
Matthew	Man	Palestinian Jewish	Jewish world	Is the Messiah King of Israel
Mark	Lion	Hellenistic Jewish	Greek-speaking world	Is the Power of God in the world
Luke	Bull	Greco-Roman	Gentile world	Is the Ideal Man of God
John	Eagle	Heavenly	Whole world	Is the Word of God

Why are there four Gospels instead of just one? One answer is that it takes four points of view to get the whole story about Jesus. Some might argue that one authoritative story should be enough. However, God chose to reveal himself using four Gospels. The Gospel of John begins with these words: “In the beginning was the Word...” (v. 1) and “the Word became flesh...” (v. 14). In other words, God chooses as his preferred method of communication to speak to humans by means of the human. This is true of the Bible and it is supremely true of Christ, whom we are told is God in the flesh (John 1:14–18).

So then, the Gospels are, like Jesus, both a Divine work as well as a human work. They have real human authors and one divine Author. They give details that might be difficult to understand, but they are never truly contradictory. They have four different points of view on the history of Jesus but only one Divine conclusion as to his identity as the Son of God.

The Gospels as Biography

The four Gospels are best understood as biographies about the life and times of Jesus. However, there are important differences between modern and ancient biographies. The main difference is the notion of historical sequencing.

Modern Biographies

- Biographies written today place a premium on sequencing.
- The events of the subject's life are typically narrated in the order in which they happened.
- Beginning with the birth of the individual, relevant events and information are viewed in sequential order up to the death of the subject.
- While chapters may present different phases in the subject's life, these phases are arranged in the order in which they are supposed to have happened.

Ancient Biographies

- Ancient biographers had a general commitment to an historical sequence.
- They did not feel the need to place every detail in their writings in the exact order in which it happened.
- Much more emphasis is given to developing an accurate picture of the character of the subject. Deeds and happenings are seen as illustrative of that character no matter when they occurred.

The Gospels as Biographies

- Luke 7:36–50 is an example of the non-sequential nature of ancient biographies. This passage is Luke's account of the woman who anoints Jesus' feet.
- Matthew, Mark, and John tell this event as part of Jesus' arrival at Bethany just before the events of Easter week (see Harmony chart).
- Despite Luke's care as an accurate historian (Luke 1:1–4), he places this event much earlier in Jesus' ministry—that is, if we read Luke like we would read a modern biography.

Jesus' Passovers

One way to measure the length of Jesus' public ministry is by counting the number of Passovers the Gospels record. Since the Passover festival only happened once a year, counting the Passovers gives a rough idea of how long Jesus' ministry lasted. The Gospels suggest that Jesus' public ministry continued for at least three years. Notice, John is the writer most concerned to give us the details about the festivals in Jesus' life.

Feast	Event or Teaching	Scripture
First Passover	Jesus went to the Passover. He cleansed the temple, talked with Nicodemus, and ministered in Judea for a while.	John 2:13–25
Second Passover	Jesus went to the “feast” (probably Passover) and healed the man at the pool of Bethesda.	John 5:1–47
Third Passover	Jesus delivered his “Bread of Life” teaching. However, he did not go to Passover because of a threat to his life in Judea.	John 6:4–7:1
Tabernacles (Booths)	Jesus went secretly for reasons of security. Teaching in the temple, he encountered opposition from the religious leaders. Jesus claimed to be the “Light of the World.” He healed the man born blind near the pool of Siloam.	John 7:2–9:41
Hanukkah (Dedication)	Jesus attended the feast. He spoke of his “sheep.” Again he escaped stoning.	John 10:22–42
Last Passover/Last Supper	Jesus went to the Passover and the last week of his life took place.	Matthew 26:17; Mark 14:12; Luke 22:7; John 12:1

Israel During Jesus' Time

Jesus' three-year ministry occurred all over the ancient cities. From Syria to Judea, Jesus brought the gospel's powerful words and actions.

[Map of Israel during Jesus' time — original map graphic omitted from this text-editable version; insert the map image from the source PDF here if desired.]

- Some have tried to resolve the difficulty by suggesting that there were two such events, two times when various women anointed Jesus' feet. But the details of Luke's account too closely resemble the other Gospel accounts to make it a separate incident.
- It is much more likely that Luke (and so the Holy Spirit) was simply using this event out of historical sequence to illustrate the Pharisees and their lack of faith in contrast to the faith of the centurion (Luke 7:2–10).

Harmony of the Gospels

Event / Period	Scripture References
The genealogy of Jesus	Matthew 1:1–17; Luke 3:23–38
Jesus' birth and childhood	Matthew 1:18–2:23; Luke 1:5–2:52
John the Baptist's ministry	Matthew 3:1–12; Mark 1:1–8; Luke 3:1–18; John 1:19–34
Christ's public ministry and first Passover	Matthew 3:13–4:12; Mark 1:9–14; Luke 3:21–4:13; John 1:35–4:42
Christ's ministry in Galilee	Matthew 4:12; Mark 1:14–15; Luke 4:14–15; John 4:43–54
His rejection at Nazareth and move to Capernaum	Matthew 4:13–22; 8:14–17; Mark 1:16–34; Luke 4:16–41
His first ministry tour and second Passover	Matthew 4:23–12:14; Mark 1:35–3:6; Luke 4:42–7:50; John 5:1–47
His second ministry tour	Matthew 12:15–13:58; Mark 3:7–6:6; Luke 8:1–56
His third ministry tour	Matthew 9:35–11:1; 14:1–12; Mark 6:6–29; Luke 9:1–9
Ministry to his disciples and third Passover	Matthew 14:13–18:35; Mark 6:30–9:50; Luke 9:10–56; John 6:1–71
Ministry in Judea	Luke 10:1–13:21; John 7:1–10:39
Ministry beyond Jordan	Matthew 19:1–20:34; Mark 10:1–52; Luke 13:22–19:27; John 10:40–11:54
The last week (Passover/Easter)	Matthew 21:12–28:20; Mark 11:1–16:20; Luke 19:28–24:53; John 11:55–21:25
Arrival in Bethany and Mary anoints Jesus' feet	Matthew 26:6–13; Mark 14:3–9; Luke 19:28; John 11:55–12:11
Triumphal entry	Matthew 21:1–11; Mark 11:1–11; Luke 19:29–44; John 12:12–19
Second cleansing of the temple; barren fig tree cursed	Matthew 21:12–13, 18–22; Mark 11:12–18; Luke 19:45–48
Greeks seek Jesus; fig tree withered	Matthew 21:19–22; Mark 11:19–25; Luke 21:37–38; John 12:20–50

Place	Event or Teaching	Scripture
Gennesaret	Healing of multitudes	Mt. 14:34–36; Mk. 6:53–56
Tyre and Sidon	Faith of the Canaanite woman	Mt. 15:21–28; Mk. 7:24–30
The Region of the Decapolis	Healing of deaf and dumb man; feeding of the 4000	Mt. 15:29–38; Mk. 7:31–8:9
Galilee	Teaching and healing	Mt. 15:39–16:5; Mk. 8:10–26
Caesarea Philippi	The question of Jesus' identity	Mt. 16:13–20; Mk. 8:27–30; Lk. 9:18–21
Galilee and Capernaum	Jesus tells of his death a second time; the half-shekel tax	Mt. 17:22–27; Mk. 9:30–50
Jerusalem	Feast of Tabernacles	Lk. 9:51; Jn. 7:2–10
Various places in Judea	Preaching tour	Lk. 10:1–24
Jerusalem	Feast of Dedication (Hanukkah)	Jn. 10:22–23
Across the Jordan	Preaching tour	Mt. 19:1; Mk. 10:1; Lk. 13:22; Jn. 10:40–42
Between Galilee and Samaria	Ten lepers healed	Lk. 17:11–19
Jericho	Jesus heals blind men	Mt. 20:29–34; Mk. 10:46–52
Bethany	The raising of Lazarus	Jn. 11:1–53
Ephraim	Jesus stays with his disciples	Jn. 11:54
Bethany, Jerusalem and vicinity	Jesus' last week (Passover/Easter)	Mt. 26:6–28:15; Mk. 14:3–16:11; Lk. 19:28–24:49; Jn. 11:55–20:31
Galilee	Appears to his disciples	Mt. 28:16–20; Mk. 16:15–18; Jn. 21:1–23
Mount of Olives	Jesus' ascension	Mk. 16:19–20; Lk. 24:50–53

Tracking Jesus' Moves

The use of this kind of harmony is also helpful to get a picture of Jesus' movements.

Place	Event or Teaching	Scripture
Bethlehem	Birth of Jesus	Mt. 1:24–25; Lk. 2:1–7
Egypt	Flight from Herod	Mt. 2:13–15
Nazareth	Early childhood	Mt. 2:19–23; Lk. 2:39
Jerusalem	Passover celebration	Lk. 2:41–52
Jordan River	Baptism of Jesus	Mt. 3:13–17; Mk. 1:9–11; Lk. 3:21–23; Jn. 1:29–34
Wilderness	Temptation of Jesus	Mt. 4:1–11; Mk. 1:12–13; Lk. 4:1–13
Going to Galilee	Calling of Philip and Nathaniel	Jn. 1:43–51
Cana in Galilee	First miracle	Jn. 2:1–11
Capernaum	Family stay	Jn. 2:12
Jerusalem	First Passover	Jn. 2:13–25
Judea	Baptizing new disciples	Jn. 3:22
Returning to Galilee	Jesus goes through Samaria	Jn. 4:1–4
Samaria	Jesus talks to the woman at the well	Jn. 4:5–42
Cana in Galilee	Healing of official's son; beginning of Galilean ministry	Jn. 4:43–54; Mt. 4:12; Mk. 1:14–15; Lk. 4:14–15
Nazareth	Rejection at Nazareth	Lk. 4:16–30
Capernaum	Move of ministry base	Mt. 4:13; Mk. 1:21; Lk. 4:31
Galilee	Preaching tour	Mt. 4:23–25; Mk. 1:32–39; Lk. 4:42–44
Jerusalem	Second Passover	Jn. 5:1–47
Galilee	The parable of the Sower and Seed	Mt. 13:1; Mk. 4:1; Lk. 8:1–4

Event / Period	Scripture References
Jesus' authority challenged	Matthew 21:23–22:46; Mark 11:27–12:37; Luke 20:1–44
Denouncing the scribes and Pharisees	Matthew 23:1–39; Mark 12:38–40; Luke 20:45–47
Widow's offering	Mark 12:41–44; Luke 21:1–4
The Olivet discourse	Matthew 24:1–25:46; Mark 13:1–37; Luke 21:5–36
Crucifixion predicted	Matthew 26:1–5; Mark 14:1–2; Luke 22:1–2
Judas's bargain	Matthew 26:14–16; Mark 14:10–11; Luke 22:3–6
Preparation and the Passover	Matthew 26:17–30; Mark 14:12–26; Luke 22:7–20; John 13:1–14:31
Discourse and high priestly prayer	John 15:1–17:26
Gethsemane	Matthew 26:36–46; Mark 14:32–42; Luke 22:39–46; John 18:1
Betrayal, arrest, and trial	Matthew 26:47–56; Mark 14:43–52; Luke 22:47–53; John 18:2–14
Jesus condemned to death and Peter's denial	Matthew 26:57–75; Mark 14:53–72; Luke 22:54–65; John 18:15–27
Formal condemnation after dawn	Matthew 27:1–2; Mark 15:1; Luke 22:66–71
Judas' suicide	Matthew 27:3–10
Jesus' first time before Pilate	Matthew 27:11–14; Mark 15:1–5; Luke 23:1–5; John 18:28–38
Jesus before Herod the Tetrarch	Luke 23:6–12; John 18:39–19:16
Jesus' second time before Pilate	Matthew 27:15–26; Mark 15:6–15; Luke 23:13–25
Soldiers mock Jesus	Matthew 27:27–31; Mark 15:16–23; Luke 23:26–33; John 19:16–17
The crucifixion	Matthew 27:32–49; Mark 15:21–36; Luke 23:26–43; John 19:18–29

Event / Period	Scripture References
Jesus' death	Matthew 27:50–56; Mark 15:37–41; Luke 23:44–49; John 19:30–37
Jesus' burial	Matthew 27:57–66; Mark 15:42–47; Luke 23:50–56; John 19:38–42
Earthquake and tomb opened	Matthew 28:1–4
Visit of women at dawn	Matthew 28:5–8; Mark 16:1–3; Luke 24:1–8; John 20:1
Women report to the apostles; Peter and John visit the tomb	Luke 24:9–12; John 20:2–10
Jesus appears first to Mary Magdalene	Mark 16:9–11; John 20:11–18
Jesus appears to other women; the guards report to the rulers	Matthew 28:9–15
Jesus appears to two on the road to Emmaus	Mark 16:12–13; Luke 24:13–32
Jesus appears to Peter	Luke 24:33–35
Jesus appears to ten, Thomas absent	Mark 16:14; Luke 24:36–43; John 20:19–25
Jesus appears to the eleven, Thomas present	John 20:26–31
Jesus appears to seven on the sea of Galilee	John 21:1–25
Jesus appears to about five hundred at an appointed mountain in Galilee	Matthew 28:16–20; Mark 16:15–18
Jesus appears to his brother James	1 Corinthians 15:7
Jesus appears to his apostles again; his ascension	Mark 16:19–20; Luke 24:44–53
Jesus appears to Paul	1 Corinthians 15:8

Parable	Scripture
The Lost Sheep	Matthew 18:10–14; Luke 15:1–7
The Lost Coin	Luke 15:8–10
The Lost Son	Luke 15:11–32
The Unrighteous Steward	Luke 16:1–13
The Rich Man and Lazarus	Luke 16:19–31
The Returning Servant	Luke 17:7–10
The Unjust Judge and the Widow	Luke 18:1–8
The Pharisee and Publican	Luke 18:9–14
The Laborers in the Vineyard	Matthew 20:1–16
The Fig Tree (2)	Matthew 21:18–22; Mark 11:12–24
The Ten Minas	Luke 19:11–27
The Two Sons	Matthew 21:28–32
The Tenants	Matthew 21:33–46; Mark 12:1–12; Luke 20:9–18
The Wedding Banquet	Matthew 22:1–14
The Fig Tree (3)	Matthew 24:32–35; Mark 13:28–31; Luke 21:29–33
The Ten Virgins	Matthew 25:1–13
The Talents	Matthew 25:14–30
The Sheep and the Goats	Matthew 25:31–46

The Parables of Jesus

Parable	Scripture
The Bridegroom, Cloth and Wineskins	Matthew 9:10–17; Mark 2:15–22; Luke 5:29–39
The Sower	Matthew 13:3–23; Mark 4:3–20; Luke 8:5–15
The Lamp	Matthew 5:15–16; Mark 4:21–25; Luke 8:16–18; 11:33
The Seed Growing	Mark 4:26–29
The Weeds	Matthew 13:24–30, 36–43
The Mustard Seed	Matthew 13:31–32; Mark 4:30–32; Luke 13:18–19
The Leaven	Matthew 13:33–35; Luke 13:20–21
The Hidden Treasure	Matthew 13:44
The Pearl of Great Price	Matthew 13:45–46
The Net	Matthew 13:47–50
The Householder	Matthew 13:51–53
On Defilement	Matthew 15:1–20; Mark 7:1–23
The Narrow Door	Matthew 7:13–14; Luke 13:22–30
The Unmerciful Servant	Matthew 18:23–35
The Good Samaritan	Luke 10:29–37
The Friend at Midnight	Luke 11:5–10
The Rich Fool	Luke 12:16–21
The Waiting Servants	Luke 12:35–38
The Watchful Householder	Matthew 24:42–44; Luke 12:39–40
The Wise Steward and the Wicked Steward	Matthew 24:45–51; Luke 12:41–48
The Fig Tree (1)	Luke 13:6–9
The Guests	Luke 14:7–11
The Banquet	Luke 14:12–24

Miracles of Jesus

The Gospel of John records the least number of miracles. Most of John's miracle accounts are not in the other Gospels. John seems to have intentionally included new material that had not previously been written down. At the same time John's focus is more on Jesus' words, his teaching, rather than on the miraculous signs Jesus did. Perhaps conscious of his readers' desire for miracle stories, John notes that even the world would not have room for the books that could be written about Jesus' many other deeds (John 21:25).

Miracle	Scripture
Water into wine	John 2:1–11
Official's son healed	John 4:46–54
Healing of demoniac in the synagogue	Mark 1:21–28; Luke 4:33–37
Healing of Peter's mother-in-law	Matthew 8:14–17; Mark 1:29–31; Luke 4:38–39
Many healed at sunset	Mark 1:32–34; Luke 4:40–41
Miraculous catch of fish	Luke 5:4–11
Healing of a leper	Matthew 8:2–4; Mark 1:40–45; Luke 5:12–16
Healing of a paralytic	Matthew 9:2–8; Mark 2:1–12; Luke 5:17–26
Healing at Bethesda	John 5:2–15
Withered hand healed in a synagogue	Matthew 12:9–14; Mark 3:1–6; Luke 6:6–11
Many healed	Matthew 12:15–21; Mark 3:7–12; Luke 6:17–19
Centurion's servant healed	Matthew 8:5–13; Luke 7:1–10
Widow's son raised at Nain	Luke 7:11–17
Demon-possessed man healed	Matthew 12:22–23; Mark 3:20–21
Calming of the storm	Matthew 8:23–27; Mark 4:36–41; Luke 8:23–25
Demonic legion cast out	Matthew 8:28–34; Mark 5:1–20; Luke 8:26–39

Miracle	Scripture
Healing of the woman with the flow of blood	Matthew 9:20–22; Mark 5:24–34; Luke 8:42–48
Raising of Jairus' daughter	Matthew 9:23–26; Mark 5:35–43; Luke 8:49–56
Healing of two blind men	Matthew 9:27–31
Healing of a mute demoniac	Matthew 9:32–34
Many healed, feeding of five thousand	Matthew 14:13–21; Mark 6:30–44; Luke 9:10–17; John 6:1–14
Walking on water and calming of the storm	Matthew 14:22–33; Mark 6:45–52; John 6:16–21
Syro-Phoenician woman's daughter healed	Matthew 15:21–28; Mark 7:24–30
Deaf mute healed	Mark 7:31–37
Many healed, feeding of four thousand	Matthew 15:29–39; Mark 8:1–10
Blind man of Bethsaida healed	Mark 8:22–26
Healing of demoniac boy	Matthew 17:14–19; Mark 9:14–29; Luke 9:37–43
Healing of the man born blind	John 9:1–7
Crippled woman healed on Sabbath	Luke 13:10–13
Healing of a man with dropsy on the Sabbath	Luke 14:2–6
Jesus raised Lazarus	John 11:38–44
Ten lepers cleansed	Luke 17:11–14
Healing of two blind men near Jericho	Matthew 20:29–34; Mark 10:46–52; Luke 18:35–43
Many healed in the temple	Matthew 21:14
Healing of the severed ear	Luke 22:51
Resurrection	Matthew 28:1–20; Mark 16:1–19; Luke 24:1–53; John 20:1–31
Miraculous catch of fish	John 21:1–8

Harmonies Through History

Over the years, people have created different types of “Gospel Harmonies.” These are some of the main types:

- Synthetic Harmonization: cuts out variation in similar accounts and replaces it with preferred wording to create a kind of “official version.”
- Sequential Harmonization: brings together two or more versions of an event by keeping both, seeing the separate details as separate incidents within the same story.
- Parallel Harmonization: shows two or more versions next to each other for comparison and contrast.

Gospel harmonies began to be produced early in the history of the church. Concern for accuracy and a full account of the gospel message became important for the church as it strove to remain faithful. These early harmonies bear witness to the church's use of the four canonical Gospels. Already by the post-apostolic age, the authority of the four to the exclusion of other texts is recognized.

Author	Title	Date
Justin Martyr	Evident in his writings	Second Century
Tatian	Diatessaron	Second Century
Unknown	Dura-Europos Harmony	Second Century
Eusebius of Caesarea	Sections and Canons	Third Century
Augustine	Consensus of the Gospels	Fourth Century
Andreas Osiander	Gospel Harmony	Sixteenth Century